THEATRE

Putting a Stoppard To It

NCPA's new production revives a Tom Stoppard satire that mixes music and political musing



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Given the dumbfounded regard that British playwright Tom Stoppard often elicits, his work can sometimes seem too daunting to perform, but *Every Good Boy Deserves Favour*—a play where actors are as integral as the on-stage orchestra—becomes even harder to stage because theatre companies invariably lack the required logistical bandwidth. It is for this reason that Bruce Guthrie, head of theatre at the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA), decided to revive it.

"We are one of the few organisations who can do a play like this because we have a world-class, inhouse orchestra," says Guthrie, whose aim has been to produce "bespoke pieces" that highlight the NCPA's strengths. For *Every Good Boy...*, he had actors at his disposal, yes, but also 45 musicians from the NCPA's Symphony Orchestra of India who will be playing instruments on stage and saying the odd line. The show runs from November 4-6.

That, though, is only half the reason for the NCPA to stage this epic production. There's also the play's subject. Set in the communist USSR, the play, a political satire, centres on two men, both named Alexander Ivanov, who share a cell in a psychiatric prison system: one is a political dissident, while the other is a schizophrenic who imagines he is the conductor of an orchestra. Guthrie knows only too well how pertinent the play feels today.



PRITHVI IS BACK IN PLAY



Covid might have forced it to close for two years, but Mumbai's Prithvi Theatre is now back with its annual festival

Committed to bringing together artistes from across the country under one roof, Mumbai's Prithvi Theatre had never missed hosting its annual performing arts festival in the four decades of its existence. That was until the pandemic forced one of the city's foremost theatrical venues to close its shutters for two years. After reopening its stage with a daily roster of plays earlier this year, Prithvi is now gearing up to host a physical edition of its theatre festival.

Slated to commence from November 3 and run till November 14, the two-week-long festival boasts a curated lineup that